

Bidu Sultanate

Background: History of Sultanate of Bidu/Girriifo, Afar

The Bidu Sultanate, a formidable power established in the early 16th century, governed the expansive territories of the present-day Afar region and the Eritrean Red Sea coastal area, known as Dankalia. This sultanate stood as a beacon of strength and resilience, defending its lands from numerous colonial powers that sought to conquer its territories. The era was marked by a vibrant landscape filled with the hustle and bustle of daily life, set against the backdrop of impending invasions.

The sultanate's military prowess was anchored in two principal dynasties: the Hamedu Siirat Dynasty, which held broad command over the sultanate's army, and the Ahawto Dynasty, which specialized in specific military fields. The Bidu Sultanate's army was a formidable force, renowned for its ability to repel invasions from powerful adversaries such as Egypt, the Ottoman Empire, Italian colonial powers, and the English during the colonial era.

This sultanate not only resisted external aggressors but also overcame internal conflicts. Notable battles such as those at Hugub Ayro, Arayah Aro, Kurruye Field, and Mattare Field were crucial in maintaining peace and order within its territories. The tales of these battles are etched in the oral literature and narratives passed down through generations, underscoring the sultanate's unwavering commitment to protecting its people.

Diplomatically, the Bidu Sultanate managed to forge and maintain relationships with neighboring regions, including the kingdoms of Tigray and Shewa, as well as the larger highland Ethiopian Empires, such as Milik and Haile Selassie. However, these relationships were not always stable, often fluctuating due to power shifts within these neighboring kingdoms.

The Afar people, ruled under five kingdoms in present-day Ethiopia, Eritrea, and Djibouti, had a unique system of governance. The Bidu Sultanate, along with the kingdoms of Rahayta, Togorra, Gobaqad, and Awsa, played a pivotal role in managing and resolving conflicts through traditional systems. The Makabanna system, a form of reconciliation assembly, was integral to this process. Customary law, known as Bur'li Mad'a, was vital in resolving conflicts. The sultanate employed a hierarchical system for conflict management, which included roles such as the Burah Abba (Father of Home), Kedoh Abba (Clan Leader), Haxah Abba (Father of Tree), and the Arkayto (Kingdom or Sultanate). This hierarchy ensured that conflicts were resolved efficiently and justly, maintaining social cohesion and harmony within the community.

The Bidu Sultanate took a keen interest in conflict resolution, employing rituals and customary law in different scenarios. The Bidu Wareda, a district in the northern part of the Afar Regional State bordering Eritrea, serves as a focal point for this research. The traditional conflict management and resolution mechanisms of the Bidu Sultanate are still practiced among the Afar people today, demonstrating the enduring legacy of these time-honored traditions.

The story of the Bidu Sultanate is not just one of military might and diplomatic maneuvering but also of a deep commitment to the welfare of its people. It faced numerous sacrifices, both internal and external, to ensure the freedom and safety of the Afar territories. This rich history, encapsulated in narratives and oral literature, continues to inspire and inform the present-day Afar community, highlighting the enduring strength and resilience of their ancestors.

The Resilient Realm of the Bidu Sultanate: Location and Traditional Territory

The Bidu Sultanate, like all sultanates and kingdom units, had well-defined territorial boundaries, also known as xinto, which delineated its administrative borders. These boundaries were essential for exercising power and implementing laws within the sultanate. However, these administrative borders were occasionally affected by various geopolitical factors, including colonial invasions.

Throughout history, the Bidu Sultanate faced physical invasions by colonial powers such as Egypt, the Ottoman Empire, Italy, and England. Despite these challenges, the sultanate's strong social cohesion and resilience ensured that it remained steadfast in its original territory. This unyielding commitment to its land and people allowed the Bidu Sultanate to persist and thrive.

The Bidu Sultanate, established in the early 16th century, was a significant power in the Horn of Africa, ruling over the present-day Afar region and the Eritrean Red Sea coastal area known as Dankalia. This sultanate maintained well-defined territorial boundaries, known as xinto, which were essential for exercising power and implementing laws. Despite facing physical invasions by various colonial powers, including Egypt, the Ottoman Empire, Italy, and England, the sultanate remained steadfast due to its strong social cohesion and resilience. Today, the Bidu Sultanate is unique as the only Afar sultanate with transnational boundaries, exercising its authority in both Ethiopia and Eritrea. Its territorial boundaries extend from Asseb in southeastern Dankalia to the northern and central zones of the Afar region in Ethiopia. This enduring influence highlights the Bidu Sultanate's historical significance and resilience, as it continues to play a vital role in maintaining social cohesion and protecting its people from internal and external aggressors. The sultanate's ability to preserve its traditional territory and power is a testament to its unyielding commitment to its land and cultural heritage.

Political System and Social Institutions

The Afar Sultanate of Bidu serves as the hereditary traditional political authority for the Afar people residing in the Dankalian region, Zone Two, Zone Four, and Kori Woreda within the Afar Regional State of Ethiopia. This political system operates on an egalitarian and social democratic framework, embracing principles of communal democracy.

The legitimacy of the Sultanate derives from the Afar people's profound respect and loyalty, known as "kuux kee konnabna" (respect and loyalty), which encompasses their sovereignty and collective wishes. Historically, this hereditary system has primarily followed ancestral lineage. However, in some instances, it has been influenced by acts of loyalty, respect, and bravery, with leadership roles being assigned to those who exemplify these qualities.

The Afar Sultanate has consistently upheld justice and lawful virtues, striving to protect the rights and territorial boundaries of the Afar people. This political system ensures that decisions are made with the community's best interests at heart, promoting a harmonious and just society.

In addition to its political framework, the Sultanate oversees various social institutions that play a crucial role in maintaining social cohesion and order. These institutions include traditional councils, conflict resolution mechanisms, and community gatherings, where issues are discussed and resolved through collective decision-making processes.

By preserving these age-old traditions and adapting to contemporary challenges, the Afar Sultanate of Bidu continues to be a cornerstone of the Afar people's cultural heritage and identity.

In the Bidu Sultanate, power and delegation were distributed across various corners of the Afar region, represented by individuals known as "makabon." The fundamental philosophy of the sultanate was rooted in equality, with a belief that all clans were equal. Every individual family held the right to select their elder, or "keyti abba," who would be responsible for the affairs of that specific family. This

selection process was free from external interference, ensuring that the family's wishes were respected.

To maintain peace and stability within the community, it was customary for the eldest member to become the family's elder upon the passing of the parent. This process extended to the knee, clan, and tribal levels, creating a system based on respect and loyalty. The sultanate appointed envoys from each clan or tribe to manage the collective issues of the clans. If an issue proved challenging for the clan leader to resolve, it would follow a procedure where the matter was escalated to the "harah abba" and, if necessary, ultimately to the sultanate.

Throughout the centuries, the Bidu Sultanate saw numerous kings and chiefdoms. However, the writer will focus on the sultans who ruled over the Arkayto for the past five centuries, highlighting their contributions and legacy.

The Bidu Sultanate's commitment to equality and fair governance was reflected in its hierarchical structure. The "Burah Abba" (Father of Home) played a crucial role in managing family affairs, while the "Kedoh Abba" (Clan Leader) oversaw the clan's wellbeing. The "Haxah Abba" (Father of Tree) ensured the stability of the larger community, and the "Arkayto" (Kingdom or Sultanate) provided overarching leadership. Even today, these practices are still observed among the Afar people, demonstrating the enduring legacy of the Bidu Sultanate's governance:

Sultan Yassin Haysma's Historical Highlights

Sultan Yassin Haysma was a prominent figure in the history of the Afar people, known for his bravery and leadership. The Afar people, also known as the Danakil, are a Cushitic-nomadic group found in East African countries like Eritrea, Djibouti, Somalia, and Ethiopia. The Bidu Sultanate, where Sultan Yassin Haysma ruled, was known for its resistance against foreign invasions.

Sultan Yassin Haysma was a key leader in the Afar resistance against the Italian colonial forces led by Mussolini. His leadership and courage were instrumental in the Afar people's struggle to protect their land and culture. Despite being captured and killed by Mussolini's army in 1931, Sultan Yassin Haysma's legacy continues to inspire the Afar people.

The Afar people have a rich cultural heritage and are known for their warrior traditions and expertise in using knives and daggers. They have a distinct culture, and their unique economic pursuits and livelihood are dependent on their traditional territories and resources.

Sultan Yassin Haysma's legacy is a testament to the remarkable resilience and ingenuity of the Afar people. Despite lacking sophisticated weaponry, his leadership and unwavering determination guided the Afar in their struggle against Italian colonization.

Yassin Haysma and his warriors employed guerrilla tactics, utilizing the harsh terrain and their intimate knowledge of the land to outmaneuver the better-armed Italian forces. The Afar people were adept at using traps and ambushes, making their rugged homeland a formidable challenge for invaders. Among their arsenal was the Abu Habba, a traditional firearm that, though simple, was effectively employed in their defense.

Sultan Yassin Haysma's courage and sacrifice for the freedom of the Afar people have left an enduring mark on history. His defiance in the face of overwhelming odds continues to inspire generations of Afar in present-day Ethiopia and Eritrea. His story is one of strength, resourcefulness, and an unyielding spirit, demonstrating that true power lies not in the sophistication of one's weapons but in the strength of one's resolve and the unity of their people.

Sultan Mohammed Ahaw

Mohammed Ahaw was a remarkable leader and warrior who played a significant role in the history of the Afar people in both Ethiopia and Eritrea. After the death of Sultan Yassin Haysma, Mohammed Ahaw took up the mantle of leadership and sought to avenge the Italian colonization that had claimed the life of his predecessor. His determination and bravery were evident as he led his people in their struggle for freedom.

In addition to external threats, Mohammed Ahaw faced internal challenges as well. The Waydarat robbery group was notorious for raiding Afar lands and stealing livestock from innocent people. As the Sultan, Mohammed Ahaw had to defend his people from these internal threats while also dealing with the displacement of his people from their original homeland to what is now known as Zone Four, Golina Woreda.

Despite these challenges, Mohammed Ahaw remained steadfast in his commitment to protecting his people. He personally led his warriors into battle, demonstrating his courage and dedication. Many brave heroes were lost in these battles, but Mohammed Ahaw's leadership and involvement in the battlefield earned him a revered place in Afar history. He was one of the few Sultans who actively participated in combat, following in the footsteps of Sultan Yassin Haysma and Ahaw Hanfare.

Mohammed Ahaw's legacy is a testament to his resilience and unwavering commitment to his people. His story is one of bravery, sacrifice, and the enduring spirit of the Afar people.

Sultan Mohammed Ahaw's leadership was marked by a remarkable blend of strength and diplomacy. Recognizing the importance of unity and stability, he sought to address the internal turmoil caused by robbery groups. Through peaceful negotiations, he forged agreements with the leaders of these groups, including their King Lul Mangessa. These agreements established a sense of neighborhood and brotherhood between the Afar and Tigray people in neighboring areas such as Abqala, Magale, Erebt, Barahle from the northern front, and Golina, Yallo from the central zone front.

Sultan Mohammed Ahaw's efforts extended beyond merely quelling internal conflicts. He understood the value of economic collaboration and established market ties between the Afar and Tigray people, particularly in the Yallo market. This market, still prominent in Zone Four, Yallo Woreda, became a hub for economic cooperation and fostered a sense of community and mutual respect between the two groups. The market not only facilitated trade but also played a significant role in changing the attitudes and behaviors of the robbery groups, encouraging them to abandon their criminal activities in favor of peaceful and productive endeavors.

The legacy of Sultan Mohammed Ahaw is a testament to his visionary leadership and dedication to the welfare of his people. His ability to unite different communities and promote economic collaboration left an enduring impact on the Afar and Tigray people, fostering a sense of unity and shared prosperity that continues to be celebrated today.

Military power or Capabilities

The sultanate's military prowess was anchored in two principal dynasties: the Hamedu Siirat Dynasty, which held broad command over the sultanate's army, and the Ahawto Dynasty, which specialized in specific military fields. The Bidu Sultanate's army was renowned for its ability to repel invasions from powerful adversaries such as Egypt, the Ottoman Empire, Italian colonial powers, and the English during the colonial era. Notable battles at Hugub Ayro, Arayah Aro, Kurruye Field, and Mattare Field were crucial in maintaining peace and order within its territories.

The Bidu Sultanate played a crucial role in shaping the military capabilities and cultural identity of the Afar people in the early 16th century. One of its most significant contributions was the introduction of specialized knives known as *Bidu Gile* and *Bori Gile*. These knives were not merely weapons but also symbols of strength, resilience, and craftsmanship, embodying the ingenuity of the Bidu Sultanate. By standardizing and promoting the use of these knives across the Afar region, the sultanate succeeded in militarizing the Afar people, strengthening their ability to defend their territories effectively. These weapons became an integral part of the Afar warrior tradition, instilling a sense of unity and pride among the people.

Before the advent of firearms, the Bidu and Bori knives were central to the Afar's military strategies. These blades were expertly crafted to suit the rugged terrain and the unique combat style of the Afar warriors. The training in the use of these knives was widespread, ensuring that the Afar people were always prepared to confront threats, both internal and external. This militarization not only provided them with a means of defense but also fostered a collective identity rooted in bravery and self-reliance.

The legacy of the Bidu Sultanate's military innovations continues to resonate among the Afar people today. The introduction of these traditional weapons laid the foundation for their renowned warrior culture, which played a significant role in resisting external invasions throughout their history. The knives, and the values they represented, are a testament to the vision and foresight of the Bidu

Sultanate in empowering the Afar people and solidifying their resilience in the face of adversity. This period of militarization underscored the sultanate's enduring commitment to protecting the land, culture, and heritage of the Afar people

Traditional Customary Law Buqili Madqa and Justice System

The origins of the Afar Customary Laws, known as “Mada,” cannot be pinpointed to a specific epoch. It is certain, however, that every valley had its own legal procedures governing the daily activities of its population. “Bur Eali Mada” is a refined collection of these valley-specific laws from the Bidu, Araata, and Eiddi regions. According to researchers, an initiative for a general conference of these three regions was launched by the Sultanate of Grifo in the Bidu region. Elders from the Araata region were invited, and it was agreed that the conference would take place in the village of Eiddi. The conference aimed to consolidate the existing valley-specific laws into one unified code. This event was conducted in an atmosphere of mutual understanding and beneficial cooperation, culminating in a successful debate. The unified code was named “Bur Eali Mada,” derived from the tribe of Bur Eali, which took the initiative in organizing the conference. To facilitate amendments and reviews, it was agreed that yearly sessions would be convened for two consecutive years. The first review conference lasted six months, and the second lasted three months, with both taking place in Eiddi. Over time, the unified code gained widespread acceptance among the Afar people, and “Bur Eali Mada” became synonymous with universality and certainty.

The Afar customary law, known as “Mada,” is a traditional legal system deeply rooted in the cultural norms and values of the Afar people, primarily residing in the Horn of Africa, including Ethiopia, Eritrea, and Djibouti. This ancient legal framework has been transmitted orally across generations, serving as a cornerstone of the Afar community's social, economic, and political relations. Mada encompasses various aspects of daily life and plays a critical role in conflict resolution and maintaining social order. The law is meticulously structured, covering principles such as the nature of crimes, types of crimes, responsibility, punishment, and compensation. Crimes are categorized into five main types: Eido (killing), Aymissiya (injury), Rado (property crimes), Samo (adultery), and Dafu (insult or defamation). A unique aspect of Mada is the principle of collective responsibility, where accountability extends beyond the individual perpetrator to their entire clan or tribe, fostering a strong sense of moral accountability and encouraging the community to work cohesively to prevent and resolve conflicts.

A vital component of Mada is the Burqili Madqa, a traditional assembly focusing on reconciliation and conflict resolution, involving elders, leaders, and representatives from various clans. The process ensures fairness and justice through extensive deliberation. The hierarchy within the Afar customary law system includes key roles such as Burah Abba (Father of Home), Kedoh Abba (Clan Leader), Haxah Abba (Father of Tree), and Arkayto (Kingdom or Sultanate), ensuring efficient conflict resolution and social cohesion. The traditional conflict management mechanisms of the Bidu Sultanate, such as the Makabanna reconciliation assembly, continue to be practiced today, demonstrating the enduring legacy of these time-honored traditions.

The basic principles of Burqili Madqa encompass several fundamental aspects that ensure justice and social order within the Afar community. Firstly, the essences of Burqili Madqa are deeply rooted in the cultural and moral values of the Afar people, emphasizing fairness, respect, and communal harmony. The types of crimes addressed by this traditional legal system include offenses related to bodily harm, property damage, and social misconduct, each categorized based on the severity and nature of the act. Responsibility within Burqili Madqa is not limited to the individual perpetrator but extends to their entire clan or tribe, fostering a collective sense of accountability. This approach encourages community members to work together in preventing and resolving conflicts. The categories of crimes are

meticulously defined, covering a wide range of offenses such as Eido (killing), Aymissiya (injury), Rado (property crimes), Samo (adultery), and Dafu (insult/defamation).

Punishment under Burqili Madqa is designed to be proportionate to the offense committed, with a focus on restorative justice. It includes various forms of compensation for the victims, addressing both physical and emotional harm. The system recognizes the different degrees of bodily injuries, ensuring that the punishment and compensation reflect the severity of the injury inflicted. Compensation in Burqili Madqa is a vital aspect, aimed at restoring the victim's dignity and wellbeing. It often involves material reparations and public apologies to mend the social fabric of the community. Execution of these principles is carried out through a hierarchical system involving elders, clan leaders, and the sultanate, ensuring that justice is administered fairly and efficiently.

Overall, Burqili Madqa's principles highlight the Afar people's commitment to maintaining social cohesion, justice, and harmony through a traditional legal framework that has stood the test of time. The Afar customary law's resilience and adaptability over time highlight the Afar people's commitment to justice, equality, and communal responsibility, preserving their cultural heritage and fostering a cohesive and peaceful society.

Economic and Taxation System of Afar, Bidu Sultanate

The Bidu Sultanate employed various economic practices to ensure the prosperity and sustainability of its people. Animal rearing, particularly of camels, played a significant role in their economy. Camels, referred to as "amoyi Gaala" and known as Wahili, were considered a form of capital and guarantee. These camels were used as a means of microfinance for poor families, enabling them to rear and utilize the camels as their own.

Taxation was another crucial aspect of the Bidu Sultanate's economic domain. The sultanate levied taxes on cities, the Afdeera Salt Lake, and markets such as the Yallo market and the Waytale market. These markets were established by the sultanate itself, providing a structured system for economic transactions. Additionally, the sultanate engaged in gold mining and exportation through the Red Sea. During ancient times, they used "Amole" salt stones as a form of foreign currency, facilitating trade with neighboring regions.

However, the advent of colonial empires, internal political instability, and regime changes significantly impacted the sultanate's taxation system. Despite these challenges, the sultanate continued to utilize agriculture as an economic option. The Awsa region, with its bilateral relationship with the brotherhood Awsa Sultanate, played a vital role in providing agricultural produce to feed soldiers and the wider community. Although the topography of the sultanate's inhabited areas was not ideal for agriculture, they engaged in agricultural activities during the summer months.

The Bidu Sultanate's economic practices were diverse and adaptive, ensuring the welfare of its people through animal rearing, taxation, mining, and agriculture. Despite external and internal challenges, the sultanate's commitment to economic sustainability remained steadfast.

Cultural Significance and Legacy

The cultural heritage of the Bidu Sultanate is rich and diverse, reflecting the unique traditions and practices of the Afar people. The sultanate was a center of cultural exchange, where traditional music, dance, and art flourished. The Afar people are known for their vibrant oral literature, which includes epic poems and stories passed down through generations, preserving the history and values of the community.

The Bidu Sultanate's legacy is also evident in its architectural contributions, with structures that showcase the traditional Afar building techniques and designs. These buildings, often constructed with locally sourced materials, are a testament to the ingenuity and adaptability of the Afar people in their harsh desert environment.

The Bidu Sultanate was a traditional governance system of the Afar people, known for its role in preserving their cultural heritage and autonomy. It was instrumental in maintaining the Afar's customary laws, warrior traditions, and resistance to colonial invasions, including Italian forces. The sultanate emphasized leadership through elders and unity, fostering resilience and cultural pride among the Afar. Its legacy endures as a symbol of the Afar people's courage, resourcefulness, and commitment to their ancestral land and traditions.

Today, the Bidu Sultanate's influence can still be seen in the social and cultural practices of the Afar people. Traditional ceremonies and rituals continue to play a vital role in community life, serving as a bridge between the past and the present. The sultanate's commitment to cultural preservation and its ability to adapt to changing circumstances have ensured the continued vitality of Afar traditions in the modern world.

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